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MODULE 2 & MODULE 3 SUMMARY

Study session 1: Organisational memory, in contrast to individual memory, encompasses the collective ability of an organization to generate, store, and retrieve knowledge and information. This concept includes the influence of an organization's history on decision-making, as shared understandings become part of the organizational culture and persist even after key individuals leave. The process of organizational memory involves five retention facilities:

Individuals: The knowledge and experiences of individual employees. Culture: The language and frameworks within the organization that shape shared interpretations. Transformations: The formalized systems and procedures reflecting the firm's past experiences. Structures: The social interactions and expectations among individuals within and outside the organization. External activities: Knowledge and information from sources outside the organization, such as former employees, government bodies, and competitors.

Retrieval of organizational memory can be controlled or automatic, depending on whether it's a deliberate attempt to access stored knowledge or an intuitive, effortless process as part of established actions.

Two types of knowledge are distinguished within organizational memory:

Artefacts of Cooperation: These are tangible indicators like products, collaboration records, and documented common knowledge, easily storable and accessible.

Knowledge of the Organization Qua Entity: This includes knowledge of the organization's political system, culture, and how things are typically done, as well as knowing who the experts are and where to find specific information or help. Different perspectives on organizational memory exist, with IT practitioners emphasizing data warehousing and document management, while organizational development (OD) approaches focus on tacit knowledge, social interactions, and ad hoc knowledge exchange. In the context of knowledge management (KM), defining organizational memory precisely isn't as critical as understanding its scope, the complex retention facilities involved, and the various types of knowledge it encompasses. Subsequent sections will delve into the role of IT in supporting and enhancing organizational memory.

Study session 2: Organizational learning is the process of creating, retaining, and transferring knowledge within an organization, which helps it improve over time through gained experience. This knowledge can encompass various aspects that benefit the organization, such as increasing production efficiency or enhancing investor relations. Knowledge creation occurs at individual, group, organizational, and inter-organizational levels.

Individual Learning: This is the smallest unit of learning where an individual acquires new skills or knowledge. Whether this knowledge is shared with the group is a critical factor in organizational learning. If the individual leaves without sharing, the group loses that knowledge.

Group Learning: This occurs when individuals within a group acquire, share, and combine knowledge through their collective experiences. It can involve feedback-driven action or the sharing of individual knowledge within the group.

Organizational Learning: This involves how an organization creates and organizes knowledge related to its functions and culture. Organizational learning happens across all activities and at different speeds, aiming to adapt to changing environments and increase efficiency.

Inter-organizational Learning: Different organizations in an alliance collaborate, share knowledge, and learn from each other. This can lead to process improvement, innovation, and cost reduction. It is essential for organizations to create an ideal learning environment, understand why something is learned, and ensure that the learning is useful.

However, there are pitfalls in organizational learning:

Failure as a Learning Experience: Failure can be a rich source of learning. Organizations should not solely reward success and stigmatize failure, as both can provide valuable insights.

Ambiguity of Success: The interpretation of success can vary within an organization and change over time. What's considered successful today might not be in the future.

Superstitious Learning: Positive or negative outcomes can be wrongly associated with actions, leading to superstitious learning. Organizations should focus on examining information generated from actions rather than arbitrary success or failure criteria for true learning.

In summary, organizational learning is a dynamic process involving various levels of knowledge creation and sharing, and it's important to embrace failure as a learning opportunity and avoid superstitious learning to foster true organizational development.

Study session 3: There are two main approaches to organizational learning:

Cognitive Approach: This view treats the organization as a whole and examines learning from a cognitive perspective, where the organization is likened to a large brain composed of its individual members.

Community-Based Approach: In this approach, learning is seen as community-based, where practitioners within the organization create knowledge in their own networks known as communities of practice. These communities involve members who interact to pursue common practices.

These approaches should be seen as complementary rather than contradictory, and they provide different perspectives on organizational learning.

Organizational Learning Theory from a Company Perspective: Chris Argyris and Donald Schon have made significant contributions to this field. They emphasize that learning occurs when there is a discrepancy between expected and actual outcomes, leading to inquiry and interaction among individuals in the organization. They distinguish between "espoused theory" (formalized instructions) and "theory-in-use" (actual problem-solving practices). Effective learning often relies on the latter, and organizations should create an environment conducive to informal problem-solving and inquiry.

Types of Learning: Argyris and Schon identify three levels of learning within organizations:

Single Loop Learning: Involves adjusting strategies based on unexpected results (error correction).

Double Loop Learning: Results in a change in the underlying theories and assumptions guiding actions to create a more efficient environment.

Deutero Learning: Focuses on improving the learning system itself, essentially learning how to learn.

These levels of learning are essential for continuous organizational improvement.

Organizational Learning and Communities of Practice: Communities of practice, introduced by Lave and Wenger, are groups of professionals informally bound by common problems and solutions. Learning within these communities is a social process, where individuals become integrated into the community and its culture, shaping their views and interpretations of the world. Learning occurs through participation, and newcomers progress from peripheral to full participation. Canonical

(formal) and non-canonical (informal) practices are discussed, with an emphasis on the importance of unstructured dialogue and storytelling for innovation and problem-solving.

Implications for Knowledge Management (KM): Key factors regarding communities of practice include the social nature of learning, the integration of knowledge into the community's culture, the inseparability of learning and community membership, the importance of learning by doing, and the empowerment of individuals and their communities. KM must understand and support these communities, which may involve mapping them, and finding innovative ways to transfer and combine knowledge across the organization, such as through cross-functional project teams. KM initiatives should be supportive, non-disruptive, and should not enforce rigid practices. Recognizing and supporting communities of practice is crucial for effective KM.

Study session 4: Organizational culture encompasses the behaviours and the significance people attach to these behaviours within an organization. It includes collective values, beliefs, principles, and is influenced by factors like history, product, market, technology, management style, and national culture. Organizational culture consists of vision, values, norms, systems, symbols, language, assumptions, beliefs, and habits. It impacts how people interact within the organization, with clients, and stakeholders. Culture also influences employees' identification with the organization. Organizational culture exists in various types of organizations, including businesses, schools, universities, government agencies, and not-for-profit groups. In business, terms like corporate culture and company culture are often used interchangeably with organizational culture. Culture is central to knowledge sharing within organizations. It determines values and beliefs, shapes what individuals perceive, and affects their willingness to share knowledge. Culture includes shared perceptions of reality and influences how things are seen and done.

One allegory illustrates how culture can persist: When apes are conditioned not to climb a ladder for a banana through punishment, even when the punishment is removed and new apes replace the original ones, the cultural learning of not climbing the ladder persists because "that's the way it has always been around here." Organizational culture has different levels, including: 1. artifacts (visible elements), 2. espoused values (leaders' values), and 3. assumptions (the actual values). A significant mismatch between these levels can cause issues within an organization. The importance of a culture conducive to knowledge sharing is emphasized in knowledge management (KM) literature. The culture at both organizational and community levels influences knowledge sharing willingness. Reciprocity, the expectation of a return on shared knowledge, plays a crucial role.

However, internal competition within the organization can hinder knowledge sharing and creation. Managing organizational culture can be challenging due to its self-reinforcing nature, learned responses, and the application of past lessons without understanding their reasons. It can contain falsehoods and lead to inappropriate reactions in the current environment. In the context of the knowledge economy, the concept of the "learning organization" is crucial. Learning organizations continuously expand their capacity to create desired results, fostering new patterns of thinking, collective aspiration, and shared understanding. To become a learning organization, five dimensions must be mastered: systems thinking, personal mastery, mental models, building shared vision, and team learning. Leaders play a pivotal role in creating learning organizations. They take on three roles: designer (creating a common vision, policies, strategies, and effective learning processes), teacher (working with mental models), and steward (serving a greater purpose of building better organizations). These roles are essential for effective knowledge management and organizational learning.

MODULE 3

Study session 1: This module discusses knowledge management (KM) and various models used to understand and implement it. KM involves several steps that are influenced by various factors (i.e. Identification of needs, identification of knowledge resources, acquisition, creation, or elimination of knowledge related resources, retrieval, application and sharing of knowledge and storage of knowledge). KM frameworks vary in complexity and focus, often addressing three main questions: What/How, Why, and When.

The "What/How" question deals with the processes of KM, often in more process-oriented models. "Why" and "When" are typically addressed in more strategic models, offering a broader perspective.

Two KM models are presented:

The KM Matrix by Gamble and Blackwell (2001): This model outlines four stages in the KM process: locating knowledge sources, organizing knowledge, socializing and sharing knowledge, and internalizing knowledge. However, it focuses mainly on knowledge sharing and omits other crucial KM processes.

The Knowledge Management Process Model by Botha et al (2008): This model offers a more realistic view of KM, emphasizing managerial initiatives. It includes the creation of new knowledge as a KM initiative. It also highlights the balance between people-oriented and technology-focused aspects of KM.

The study session concludes with an "integrated knowledge management model" that draws from various sources. It involves sequential steps: Detect & Discover, Organize & Assess, and KM Tactical and Strategic Initiatives. These initiatives include actions like knowledge reuse, creation/acquisition, investment, and divestment. The model emphasizes that information systems play a crucial role in supporting these processes and that it's a continuously evolving system. This study session acknowledges that KM is a vast and evolving field, and any model can only capture a part of its complexity.

Study Session 2: Study session 2 introduces various knowledge management (KM) processes and initiatives based on the integrated knowledge management model. The primary KM processes covered include:

1. Knowledge Discovery and Detection: This process involves uncovering knowledge within the organization, including explicit knowledge found in documents and data, tacit knowledge gathered through surveys and interviews, and embedded knowledge within organizational routines and processes. Furthermore, sources of knowledge for organizations may outside the organization and according to Blackwell these sources include Alliances, Suppliers, Customers.

Facilitating Knowledge Discovery and Detection: Practices to make knowledge easier to find, such as documenting work processes and using generalists to organize knowledge, are discussed.

2. Knowledge organization and assessment: Knowledge Organization and Assessment involves structuring and categorizing knowledge resources for effective management. This process encompasses activities like classifying, mapping, indexing, and categorizing knowledge, making it easily navigable, storable, and retrievable (Botha et al., 2008). Markus (2001) suggests that a "knowledge intermediary," which could be a knowledge manager or even the original creator of the knowledge, plays a vital role in preparing, sanitizing, and organizing knowledge. The goal is to ensure that knowledge can be readily identified, retrieved, and

comprehended by knowledge users. This organized knowledge can then be shared for various purposes, including reuse in business scenarios and as a foundation for creating new knowledge.

3. Explicit knowledge organization is strongly recommended for efficient knowledge management. IT-based systems employ taxonomies and ontologies to categorize and structure knowledge and information in a logical, hierarchical manner. This enables users to easily navigate and access information by category. However, it's important to note that creating taxonomies can be a costly endeavour. Even though explicit knowledge may not be as highly valued as tacit knowledge, its sheer volume necessitates an effective method of classification and retrieval. In addition to taxonomies and ontologies, other tools like libraries and data marts are also used for organizing explicit knowledge resources.
4. Tacit knowledge organization: Organizing tacit knowledge involves employing strategies such as focus groups, expertise guides, social network analysis, and knowledge coordinators. Knowledge coordinators play a key role in understanding the context in which tacit knowledge was developed. To identify and categorize valuable sources of tacit knowledge, expertise locators like corporate yellow pages, social network analysis, and knowledge maps are used. These tools not only pinpoint where experts with valuable tacit knowledge are located within the organization but also reveal the extent of the knowledge's distribution. This information can be instrumental in strategic planning, especially in preparing for the retirement of key employees holding critical tacit knowledge.
5. Embedded knowledge organisation: Organizing embedded knowledge involves several strategies, including job/workplace design, workflow analysis, and performance measurement as suggested by Gamble & Blackwell (2001). Mapping, especially knowledge maps outlining embedded knowledge, can be beneficial, and these maps can be developed with guidance from knowledge brokers, as proposed by Horvath (2000). Similar to other forms of knowledge, Liebowitz emphasizes the importance of assessing embedded knowledge within the organization. The key considerations here are the severity or criticality of the knowledge and its availability. Knowledge that is both highly critical to the organization and scarce, such as when it is held by only one or a few experts, or those nearing retirement age, warrants special attention and management. This assessment helps in prioritizing the handling of embedded knowledge resources.
6. Knowledge organisation: Organizing and assessing knowledge can appear costly, and the return on investment may not be immediately evident since the benefits are often indirect. However, despite the lack of immediate visible gains, this process is a crucial step in effective knowledge management and reuse within an organization. To make this process more efficient, organizations can implement systems that facilitate the detection and organization of knowledge. The specific systems employed should align with the context in which the knowledge was generated and the potential users. Further insights into this aspect are provided in the recommendations section of the knowledge reuse subsection.

Study session 3: Knowledge sharing

The process of knowledge sharing can be categorized into "push" and "pull" approaches. "Pull" involves knowledge workers actively seeking knowledge sources, while "push" involves knowledge being delivered to users without them actively seeking it. Successful knowledge sharing, particularly explicit knowledge, relies on criteria such as articulation, awareness, access, guidance, and completeness. IT plays a crucial role in facilitating explicit knowledge sharing through content management systems and document management systems.

Explicit knowledge sharing systems, when implemented effectively, can offer short-term advantages and contribute to competitive advantage in a world flooded with explicit knowledge according Bukowitz and williams the criteria for successful knowledge sharing are: articulation, awareness,

access, guidance, and completeness. However, their transparency makes them easy to replicate, limiting their long-term competitive advantage potential.

Tacit knowledge sharing, on the other hand, relies on socialization and informal networks within the organization. It involves fostering a culture conducive to sharing, supporting unstructured work environments that encourage experimentation, and utilizing knowledge managers to bridge gaps between communities. While IT can support tacit knowledge sharing, it should not replace social interaction, problem-solving, mentoring, and teaching, which are essential for sharing tacit knowledge. IT's role in tacit knowledge sharing includes expert finding and, to some extent, supporting various forms of communication.

Embedded knowledge sharing pertains to transferring knowledge embedded in products, processes, or routines to other areas. Techniques like scenario planning, after-action reviews, and management training can facilitate this process. IT plays a role as a repository for embedded knowledge, supporting practices and routines. Therefore, effective knowledge sharing requires the right processes, frameworks, and systems, along with a supportive knowledge-sharing culture. IT plays a significant role in facilitating explicit knowledge sharing and can provide some support for tacit knowledge sharing, but it should complement, not replace, social interactions and practices.

Study session 4: Managing Knowledge Reuse

Knowledge reuse involves the process of recovering, salvaging, or processing knowledge for use, often in different ways. There are three key roles in this process:

Knowledge Producer: This is the original creator of the knowledge.

Knowledge Intermediary: This person packages and prepares the knowledge for storage, retrieval, and sharing. This can involve various functions such as indexing, categorization, standardization, publishing, and mapping.

Knowledge Consumer: This individual receives and uses the knowledge. These roles can be performed by different people or the same person.

For tacit knowledge, the intermediary may be the expert who presents the knowledge in a usable way, or it could be someone who identifies and connects others with the expert. In any case, someone must produce, make available, and search for and use knowledge, requiring both capability and willingness to share and retrieve.

There are two general types of knowledge reuse:

Internal: The knowledge producer uses their own knowledge later.

External: The knowledge consumer uses someone else's knowledge. External reuse has a higher failure rate due to the loss of contextual information and incomplete knowledge capture.

Four specific knowledge reuse situations are identified:

Shared Work Producers: Teams create knowledge for their own reuse and generally have a good understanding of their needs but may require knowledge about how and why things were done.

Shared Work Practitioners: People performing similar work in different settings who need to know how to do something or why something works.

Expertise-Seeking Novices: Individuals seeking knowledge outside their usual expertise, which can be challenging due to their limited understanding of the topic.

Miners of Secondary Knowledge: People seeking knowledge from different contexts for application elsewhere, requiring complex search algorithms.

Managing knowledge reuse presents several challenges:

Cost: Organizing, packaging, storing, and retrieving knowledge can be expensive, especially for tacit knowledge. Maintaining context, indexing, categorization, and metadata are essential.

Specific Requirements: Different situations require tailored support. This includes maintaining context, ensuring consistency, supporting communication and informal networks, and recording expertise.

Willingness: Both producers and consumers must be willing to engage in knowledge reuse, which is influenced by organizational culture.